

UGC NET  
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# December 2026 Countdown Playbook

The complete guide to India's biggest eligibility test -  
December 14-19 exam dates, the registration window, the three-result  
system, and an 82-day plan that respects your time

Exam decoded | Eligibility & fees | The 6% rule explained | Paper 1's ten units | 82-day study  
plan | Scam protection

*For every candidate who refuses to lose a cycle to missed dates and bad information.*

Every date, rule and number in this playbook is verified from official NTA and UGC sources as on 23 September 2026.  
Where something is not yet announced, it is clearly marked as expected - never as fact.

DIGITAL EDITION | DECEMBER 2026 CYCLE

## WHAT'S INSIDE

# Twenty parts, zero filler

Each part answers one question you will actually ask between now and exam day. Numbers come from official NTA and UGC documents; anything not yet announced for the December 2026 cycle is marked **expected** with the reasoning behind it.

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**How to use this book:** read Parts 1-3 today (one sitting, 20 minutes), keep Part 5 open when the form goes live, start Part 10's plan this week, and return to Parts 9 and 11 whenever motivation dips - they are the reality check that keeps you going.

## PART 1

# Why this cycle is different - and why your timing is good

On 16 September 2026, the National Testing Agency published its advance calendar and locked the UGC NET December 2026 exam for **14-19 December 2026**, with 20-21 December kept as buffer dates. If you are reading this in late September, you have roughly **82 days** to the first exam day. That is short, but it is not the emergency it feels like - and this part explains why.

The December cycle has moved earlier than it used to be. The December 2025 exam ran from 31 December 2025 to 7 January 2026, and the December 2024 exam spilled into January 2025. This time the whole cycle finishes before Christmas. Two practical consequences follow from that single change.

- **Your prep runway is shorter than last cycle's candidates had.** Someone preparing for the December 2025 exam could study straight through the holidays; you cannot. The plan in Part 10 is built around exactly this compressed runway.
- **Results should come earlier too.** The June 2026 result arrived on 28 August 2026, about two months after the exam. A comparable December timeline would put your result in February 2027 - in time for the spring PhD admission season.

The registration window has not opened yet. Based on how NTA has run the last three December cycles, expect it in **October 2026** - the December 2025 window opened on 7 October 2025, and December 2023's opened on 30 September 2023. This book assumes an October opening and tells you exactly what to prepare now so you can file your form on day one (Part 5).

**What happened in June 2026 (and why it matters to you):** the June 2026 cycle saw three papers - English, Commerce and Sociology - cancelled after errors were found in the question papers, then re-conducted on 9-10 September 2026, with those results declared on 17 September 2026. The lesson is not panic; it is process. NTA does correct its mistakes, but corrections come through official notices only. From today, the NTA website is your single source of truth - everything else is commentary.

## PART 2

### What clearing NET actually gives you

Since June 2024, one exam produces three different results. Where you land depends on your aggregate marks and, for the Junior Research Fellowship, your age. This is the single most misunderstood part of NET, so here is the full picture from UGC's own notification.

| Result category | JRF | Assistant Professor | PhD admission | What it means                                                                               |
|-----------------|-----|---------------------|---------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Category 1      | Yes | Yes                 | Yes           | The full prize: funded research (Rs. 37,000 per month), teaching eligibility, PhD admission |
| Category 2      | No  | Yes                 | Yes           | Teaching eligibility plus PhD admission; no fellowship money                                |
| Category 3      | No  | No                  | Yes           | A national entrance route to PhD; no fellowship, no teaching eligibility                    |

### The money, spelled out

A Category-1 result makes you eligible for the Junior Research Fellowship: **Rs. 37,000 per month**, revised from Rs. 31,000 with effect from 1 January 2023, plus house rent allowance where applicable. After two years, subject to assessment, it upgrades to the Senior Research Fellowship at **Rs. 42,000 per month**. The JRF award is valid for three years from the date of the award letter. If research is your plan, this is the difference between funding your PhD and your PhD funding itself.

A Category-2 result makes you eligible for appointment as Assistant Professor - a post at Academic Level 10 of the UGC pay matrix in universities and colleges, with recruitment governed by each university's, college's or state's rules. NET clearance is the eligibility key; the actual job is a separate recruitment process you apply for afterwards.

The career logic of NET is that one 3-hour exam can underwrite a decade of career options. That's why 7.7 lakh people registered for the June 2026 cycle. But note the pyramid in Part 11 - the higher categories are genuinely competitive, which is exactly why a disciplined 82 days matters.

**PART 3****The timeline: confirmed dates and smart expectations**

Here is the honest split between what is **confirmed** and what is **expected**. Anything marked expected is reasoned from NTA's own recent cycles and is not an announcement.

| Event               | Status                                | Date                                |
|---------------------|---------------------------------------|-------------------------------------|
| Exam days           | CONFIRMED (NTA calendar, 16 Sep 2026) | 14-19 December 2026                 |
| Buffer days         | CONFIRMED                             | 20-21 December 2026                 |
| Registration opens  | Expected - Oct 2026                   | Dec 2025 cycle opened 7 Oct 2025    |
| Registration closes | Expected - around early Nov 2026      | Dec 2025 closed 7 Nov 2025          |
| Correction window   | Expected - after closing              | June 2026 ran 22-24 May 2026        |
| City intimation     | Expected - early Dec 2026             | June 2026: about 10 days pre-exam   |
| Admit card          | Expected - about a week before exam   | June 2026: 15 June for 22 June exam |
| Result              | Expected - Feb 2027                   | June 2026 result came 28 Aug 2026   |

NTA's December cycles have historically respected a pattern: the application window opens 8-11 weeks before the exam and stays open about four weeks, with extensions common (the June 2026 window was itself extended). The December 2025 cycle opened on 7 October 2025 for an exam beginning 31 December; December 2026's exam starts two weeks earlier, so a proportionally earlier October opening is the reasonable expectation.

What to do about it: do not wait for the notification to start preparing - the syllabus does not change with the notification. Check the official site ([ugcnet.nta.nic.in](http://ugcnet.nta.nic.in)) every Monday and Thursday morning until the form goes live. That is twice a week, two minutes a session - and it is how you avoid the panic-batch of candidates who discover the window three days before it closes.

**How to verify any date yourself (30 seconds)**

Three artefacts can carry an official date, in decreasing order of authority: the **information bulletin** (the legal document for the cycle), a **public notice or press release** on [ugcnet.nta.nic.in](http://ugcnet.nta.nic.in) or [nta.ac.in](http://nta.ac.in), and the **examination calendar** - like the 16 September 2026 one that fixed December dates. News articles and aggregator sites are downstream of these and frequently wrong in the details. The check: open the portal, find the notice under Public Notices, read the date line, and trust only what you can screenshot from there.

**Reminder ritual:** set two recurring phone alarms - one for Monday 9 am, one for Thursday 9 am, both labelled 'check [ugcnet.nta.nic.in](http://ugcnet.nta.nic.in)'. Delete them the day you submit your form. This single habit eliminates the most common way people lose a cycle.

**PART 4**

## Are you eligible? The complete checklist

Eligibility rules below are from the official UGC-NET information bulletin in force through 2026. Verify your personal edge cases against the December 2026 bulletin when it is released - but the framework has been stable for years.

### Education

- General / Unreserved / General-EWS: at least **55%** marks (no rounding off) in a Master's degree or equivalent, from a UGC-recognised university, in a NET subject.
- OBC (Non-Creamy Layer) / SC / ST / PwD / PwBD / Third gender: at least **50%**.
- **Final-year Master's students can apply.** You are admitted provisionally and must secure the required percentage within two years of the NET result (one year if you qualify in the PhD-only category) - otherwise you stand disqualified.
- PhD holders whose Master's was completed by 19 September 1991 get a 5% relaxation (55% effectively becomes 50%).

### Age - only the JRF has a limit

For the December 2026 cycle, you must be **not more than 30 years old on 1 December 2026** to be considered for JRF. There is **no upper age limit** for Assistant Professor eligibility or PhD admission. If you are over 30 or close to it, you can still appear and qualify for Categories 2 and 3.

| Relaxation                                    | Years   | Notes                                                    |
|-----------------------------------------------|---------|----------------------------------------------------------|
| Women applicants                              | +5      | Automatic                                                |
| OBC-NCL / SC / ST / PwD / PwBD / Third gender | +5      | Per Central OBC list on ncbc.nic.in                      |
| Research experience                           | Up to 5 | Certified research time after Master's, relevant subject |
| L.L.M. degree                                 | +3      | For law candidates                                       |
| Armed forces service                          | Up to 5 | Length of service up to 1 Dec 2026                       |

Total relaxation cannot exceed five years under any combination of grounds - so the effective maximum age for JRF is 35.

### One quiet detail worth knowing

Third-gender candidates are assigned the lowest cut-off among SC / ST / PwD / PwBD / OBC-NCL / General-EWS for each subject - a genuinely candidate-friendly provision that most aspirants never discover.

**PART 5****Fees and the application, done right**

Application is online only, at [ugcnet.nta.nic.in](http://ugcnet.nta.nic.in). The fee schedule in the June 2026 bulletin - carried below as the reference; the December bulletin confirms final numbers - plus applicable bank/gateway charges:

| Category                            | Application fee |
|-------------------------------------|-----------------|
| General / Unreserved                | Rs. 1,150       |
| General-EWS / OBC-NCL               | Rs. 600         |
| SC / ST / PwD / PwBD / Third gender | Rs. 325         |

The fee is payable by net banking, debit card, credit card or UPI, is non-refundable, and covers one subject. Only the first application counts - multiple forms for the same cycle are automatically rejected beyond the first.

**The three-step form, and what trips people**

- 1 **Register** with your own email and mobile number (never a friend's or a cyber-cafe operator's) and note the system-generated application number. NTA's June 2026 window also supported sign-in through the Meri Pehchan single sign-on and Aadhaar-based verification to simplify the process.
- 2 **Fill the form** - personal details, subject, and four preferred exam cities - and upload a recent photograph (the June 2026 bulletin specified about 10-200 KB, 80% of the face visible, ears included, white background) and your signature; certificates (category, EWS, PwD, result-awaited) go up as PDFs. Follow the bulletin's exact file-size limits - they are checked automatically.
- 3 **Pay and print** - keep the confirmation page and the fee receipt. The confirmation page is your proof of application; treat it like a hall ticket until the real one arrives.

**Five classic rejection traps**

- Name spelling that does not match your Master's marksheet exactly - NTA will not fix this for you later.
- Choosing OBC without being on the **Central** NCL list; state-list OBC candidates must apply as General/Unreserved.
- Uploading a dark selfie instead of the specified white-background photograph.
- Leaving the subject choice to the last hour of the last day - servers slow down and fee transactions fail precisely when everyone rushes.
- Not using the correction window. June 2026's ran from 22-24 May; if one opens for December 2026, use it to fix anything you got wrong.

**File on day one or two of the window, not the last week.** Every extension NTA grants attracts a fresh flood of last-minute applicants. Early filers choose exam cities calmly, avoid gateway congestion, and get two extra weeks of studying what actually matters.

### The registration-day checklist (print this page)

| Before you open the form                                  | Ready? |
|-----------------------------------------------------------|--------|
| Master's marksheet and degree (name-spelling reference)   |        |
| Aadhaar / PAN / passport (ID details)                     |        |
| Personal email + mobile that you alone control            |        |
| Subject and subject code chosen (bulletin's appendix)     |        |
| Four exam cities, in preference order                     |        |
| Category / EWS / PwD certificate PDFs, if applicable      |        |
| Photograph: white background, face 80%, correct file size |        |
| Signature scan: correct file size, running hand           |        |
| Net banking / card / UPI with limit headroom              |        |
| 45 uninterrupted minutes (not 10 at midnight)             |        |

Then the form itself is thirty minutes: register, fill, upload, pay, print the confirmation page, and screenshot the fee receipt. One sitting, done forever.



**PART 6**

## The exam, decoded: two papers, one sitting, zero negative marking

| Paper   | Questions | Marks | What it tests                                      |
|---------|-----------|-------|----------------------------------------------------|
| Paper 1 | 50        | 100   | Teaching and research aptitude - same for everyone |
| Paper 2 | 100       | 200   | Your chosen NET subject                            |
| Total   | 150       | 300   | Single 3-hour computer-based session, no break     |

Every question is a multiple-choice question worth **+2 marks**. Wrong answers cost nothing. Unattempted questions also earn nothing. There is no negative marking in UGC NET - this is official policy, printed in every recent bulletin.

The strategic consequence is worth internalising: **you attempt all 150 questions, every time, no exceptions**. In the last five minutes of each paper, every unanswered question gets your best guess. A blind guess has a positive expected value; leaving it blank has exactly zero. Candidates lose whole percentile bands by 'not guessing on principle'.

The bulletin also fixes how problem questions are handled: if more than one option turns out to be correct, everyone who attempted the question gets +2; if a question is dropped, everyone who attempted it gets +2. You do not need to worry about a bad question costing you marks.

Both papers run in one continuous 3-hour session - there is no break between Paper 1 and Paper 2. The June 2026 exam ran shifts of three hours in computer-based mode across 655 centres in 286 cities, and the December 2026 exam will follow the same CBT format. Question order, shift allocation and subject-wise scheduling come with the detailed notice closer to the exam.

### The arithmetic of 180 minutes

One hundred fifty questions in 180 minutes is 72 seconds per question - but nobody averages it that way. The workable split most toppers converge on:

| Segment                         | Time      | Pace                                             |
|---------------------------------|-----------|--------------------------------------------------|
| Paper 1, first pass             | 45 min    | Answer 40 of 50; park the 10 hardest             |
| Paper 1, second pass + guessing | 10 min    | Clear the parked ones; mark everything           |
| Paper 2, first pass             | 85-90 min | Answer 75-80 of 100; skip and flag               |
| Paper 2, second pass + guessing | 15-20 min | Return to flagged; mark every remaining question |
| Final sweep                     | 5 min     | Zero unattempted questions on screen             |

The principle behind the table: with no negative marking, a parked question is only deferred, never abandoned. Train the discipline in every mock - 'flag and move' is a motor skill, not an idea, and it is built only under a clock.

**PART 7****Paper 1: ten units, fifty questions**

Paper 1 is identical for every candidate and is organised into ten units - five questions (10 marks) from each. Its syllabus is published by UGC and downloadable from [ugcnetonline.in](http://ugcnetonline.in) (the NTA bulletin points you to the same file; NTA does not mail it to candidates). Here is each unit with what it actually tests.

| Unit | Topic                                          | What it feels like                                                                        |
|------|------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| I    | Teaching Aptitude                              | Concept, aims, levels of teaching; learner characteristics; methods; evaluation systems   |
| II   | Research Aptitude                              | Types and steps of research; thesis and article writing; research ethics; ICT in research |
| III  | Comprehension                                  | A passage with five questions - answers sit inside the text                               |
| IV   | Communication                                  | Types, barriers, and effective communication                                              |
| V    | Mathematical Reasoning and Aptitude            | Number series, fractions, ratios, interest                                                |
| VI   | Logical Reasoning                              | Argument structure, deductive reasoning, Venn diagrams, analogies                         |
| VII  | Data Interpretation                            | Tables, graphs, percentage and ratio analysis                                             |
| VIII | Information and Communication Technology (ICT) | Computer and internet basics; digital initiatives in higher education                     |
| IX   | People, Development and Environment            | SDGs, pollution, natural resources, international agreements                              |
| X    | Higher Education System                        | Governance, policies, institutions, professional and skill-based education                |

**How to attack Paper 1 in limited time**

Ten equal-mark units is good news: no single unit can sink you, and no single unit can save you. The efficient play is to treat the units as three groups with three different study methods.

**Group A - the memory four: Teaching Aptitude, Research Aptitude, Communication, Higher Education System**

These units reward one careful read plus spaced revision. Their questions test definitions, classifications and concepts - the levels of teaching (memory, understanding, reflective), learner characteristics for adolescents and adults, methods of teaching in higher education, the steps and types of research, referencing styles and research ethics, barriers to communication, and the structure and governance of Indian higher education (institutions, regulatory bodies, policies, professional and skill-based education). Make a one-page definition sheet per unit; revise it weekly. These four units are where most candidates bank their fastest 40 marks.

## **Group B - the reasoning pair: Mathematical Reasoning and Aptitude, Data Interpretation**

Nothing here is advanced mathematics - number series, fractions, percentages, ratios, compound interest, tables, graphs - but it is the pair that decides whether Paper 1 takes 55 minutes or 75. Method beats reading: twenty minutes of daily timed drill from October onward. Track your accuracy on series questions and table questions separately; most candidates find one format easier and should bank it first inside the exam. Read every question twice before computing - the questions are short but the options are close.

## **Group C - the awareness pair: Comprehension, People Development and Environment, ICT**

Comprehension is a reading-speed test wearing a reading test's clothes: five questions whose answers sit literally inside the passage. Practice reading the questions first, then the passage - for most people this halves the time per question. The Environment unit wants the Sustainable Development Goals, pollution types and international agreements (the recurring favourites); ICT wants everyday computer, internet and digital-initiative vocabulary plus higher-education platforms. Both units are current-affairs-sensitive, so refresh them in December, not September. The official syllabus file for each unit is on [ugcnetonline.in](http://ugcnetonline.in) - print it, tick topics off, and let previous-year questions tell you which topics actually repeat.

## **A note on Logical Reasoning (Unit VI)**

The sixth unit deserves its own line: argument structure, deductive reasoning, Venn diagrams and analogies. It sits between the groups - part concept, part practice - and it is the unit where coaching-material summaries genuinely help. Solve every Logical Reasoning question from the last five cycles before spending a rupee on anything else.

## PART 8

# Paper 2: your subject, your marks

Paper 2 is where the exam is won. It carries 200 of the 300 total marks, is based on the subject you pick at application time, and its official syllabus for every subject is on [ugcnetonline.in](http://ugcnetonline.in). The June 2026 exam was conducted for 87 subjects; the exact December list arrives with the bulletin.

## Choosing your subject

The default and correct rule: your Master's subject. NET eligibility is tied to your postgraduation, and university recruitment rules expect the Paper 2 subject to match what you will teach. Deviate only after checking that your degree maps to the alternate subject under the bulletin's appendix of eligible postgraduations - guessing here can invalidate an otherwise brilliant result.

## How toppers actually cover a subject

- **Previous-year questions first, books second.** Ten years of papers reveal the syllabus's true weight distribution - which units give 40 questions and which give four.
- **Three passes, not one.** Pass one builds the map (read the syllabus, tag PYQs to units). Pass two is deep coverage of the high-yield units. Pass three is revision of what you have already solved.
- **Unit tests, not marathon reading.** A 100-question paper in 100 minutes, twice a week, beats six hours of passive highlighting.
- **Answer keys are published.** NTA released June 2026's question papers, answer keys and your recorded responses together - practice with the real thing, not memory-based reconstructions.

## The source hierarchy for any subject

When two resources disagree, they resolve in this order: the official syllabus outranks every summary; previous-year papers outrank every prediction of important topics; a standard university textbook outranks coaching notes; and coaching notes outrank nothing at all except social media. Build your stack top-down: syllabus open on one side, ten years of PYQs on the other, textbook for the gaps that remain. Most candidates invert the hierarchy, study the summaries, and meet the actual paper as a stranger.

One more June 2026 lesson: when three subjects' papers were re-conducted, it was because of errors in the original papers - which candidates had flagged through the official challenge process. When your cycle's answer keys open for challenge, check your recorded responses carefully. The process works when candidates use it.

**PART 9**

## How the result is actually computed: the 6% rule

Most candidates know their score and nothing about the machinery behind it. The machinery matters because it tells you what a safe score looks like. Here is NTA's published procedure, step by step.

- 1 **Step 1 - the slot count.** The number of candidates declared eligible for Assistant Professor equals **6% of the candidates who appeared** (in both papers). Slots are then distributed across categories per the Government of India's reservation policy.
- 2 **Step 2 - the floor.** To be considered at all, you must have appeared in both papers and scored at least **40% aggregate** (General / General-EWS) or **35% aggregate** (SC, ST, OBC-NCL, PwD/PwBD, Third gender). 40% of 300 is 120 marks; 35% is 105.
- 3 **Step 3 - the cut-off falls where the slots run out.** Within each subject and category, candidates above the floor are ranked, and the cut-off lands at the aggregate score where the slots are exhausted - which is why cut-offs differ by subject and category.
- 4 **Step 4 - JRF among the top.** JRF slots are far fewer and are allocated from the top of the eligible pool (with the age limit applied). In June 2026, only about 4,241 of the 6.07 lakh who appeared (84 subjects) landed JRF - roughly 0.7%.

### The cut-off formula, with a worked example

The bulletin itself walks through how a subject-category cut-off is derived. Suppose you are an SC-category candidate in Economics:

**Qualified in Economics (SC) = (SC candidates scoring 35%+ in Economics x total SC slots across all subjects) divided by (total SC candidates scoring 35%+ across all subjects).**

The aggregate percentage at which the slots run out becomes the SC cut-off for Economics that cycle. The same yardstick produces every subject-category cut-off in the result.

Notice what this means: your cut-off is not a fixed bar set in advance - it is an auction outcome that depends on who else in your subject and category scored what, in the specific subjects they chose. You cannot control the field; you can only be far enough above the floor that the auction never reaches you.

Results are declared in percentile along with marks, and when a subject runs in multiple shifts, marks are normalised by the equi-percentile method before percentiles are computed. Your percentile is also your currency for PhD admission: under Categories 2 and 3, universities admit PhD students using **70% weight to your NET score and 30% to an interview**, and the NET score is valid for that purpose for one year from the result date.

**What a safe score looks like:** the floor (120/300 for General) is only the entry gate. The real target is the top-6% boundary, which varies by subject and category but in recent cycles has meant scoring comfortably above 55-60% aggregate to be in the conversation for Assistant Professor eligibility. Set your practice-mock target at 180/300 (60%) and you are aiming at qualification, not survival.

**PART 10****The 82-day study plan**

This plan starts 23 September 2026 and lands you at 14 December 2026. It assumes you have your Master's books and a decent internet connection, and nothing else. Total daily commitment: 3-4 hours on working days, 6-7 on Sundays. If you are working full-time, stretch each phase by doing only the bold-line tasks on weekdays and everything on weekends.

| Phase                    | Window             | Mission                                                                                                                              | Weekly rhythm                                                            |
|--------------------------|--------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Phase 1<br>Foundation    | 23 Sep -<br>31 Oct | Cover the map: full Paper 2 syllabus first pass; Paper 1 units I-IV and VIII-X; file the application the week the window opens       | 6 days study + 1 day for one full Paper 1 PYQ and unit test              |
| Phase 2<br>Consolidation | 1 Nov -<br>30 Nov  | High-yield depth in Paper 2; Paper 1 units V-VII drilled; two full-length mocks per week in exam conditions                          | 5 days topic study + 1 day mock + 1 day full mock review                 |
| Phase 3<br>Taper         | 1 Dec -<br>13 Dec  | Revision only: PYQs, formula and definition sheets, current affairs for Environment and Higher Education units; admit card logistics | Daily 3-hour timed paper alternating Paper 1 and Paper 2; light evenings |

**Phase 1 in detail (23 September - 31 October)**

- Week 1: download the official Paper 2 syllabus for your subject and the Paper 1 syllabus. Paste the unit list where you study. Collect the last ten cycles' papers from the NTA website's archive.
- Weeks 1-4: one Paper 2 unit cluster per 2-3 days, ending each cluster with 25 PYQs on that cluster. Paper 1: two units per week (start with Teaching Aptitude, Research Aptitude, Higher Education System, ICT - the high-yield, low-effort four).
- Week 5: full Paper 1 PYQ under the clock; first full Paper 2 subject test. This is your baseline - expect it to humble you; that is its job.
- Throughout: when the registration window opens (expected October), file within 48 hours per Part 5's checklist, then return to studying.

**Phase 2 in detail (November)**

- Reweight time 40:60 between Paper 1 and Paper 2. Paper 2's 200 marks decide your category; Paper 1's 100 marks decide your comfort.
- Every mock is followed by a 90-minute review the same evening: each wrong answer tagged 'did not know', 'misread', or 'ran out of time' - the tag tells you what to fix.
- Mathematical Reasoning and Data Interpretation get 20 minutes of daily drill; they are the Paper 1 units that respond fastest to reps.

**Phase 3 in detail (1-13 December)**

- No new topics. Nothing new is learnable in the last fortnight anyway - and attempts to cram fresh material only erode confidence in what you already know.
- Alternate timed full papers with active-recall revision (define, explain, solve from memory, then check).

- Week of the exam: verify admit card details, plan the route to your centre, sleep at exam-hour-compatible times, and do one light revision day before the exam.

## What done looks like, phase by phase

| By the end of    | You should be able to...                                                                           |
|------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Phase 1 (31 Oct) | Name every unit of both papers from memory; solve any PYQ from your high-yield units; form filed   |
| Phase 2 (30 Nov) | Score 160+ in a full timed mock; finish both papers with zero unattempted questions                |
| Phase 3 (13 Dec) | Score 180+ sustained; recall definition sheets cold; know your centre route and admit-card details |

Miss a milestone and the response is never panic - it is diagnosis. Take the next Sunday, locate the leaking bucket with the error log, and patch only that. Plans survive contact with real life by bending, not by being abandoned.

## The 12-week calendar at a glance

Phases are strategy; this is the wall calendar. Week 1 starts Monday, 28 September - use the first days of this week for setup and the official syllabus download.

| Week | Dates 2026     | Theme                              | Non-negotiable                          |
|------|----------------|------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------|
| 1    | 28 Sep - 4 Oct | Setup + Paper 2 start              | Syllabus printed; PYQ archive built     |
| 2    | 5 - 11 Oct     | Paper 2 cluster A                  | 25 PYQs on cluster A                    |
| 3    | 12 - 18 Oct    | Paper 2 cluster B + Paper 1 groups | Registration opens - FILE THE FORM      |
| 4    | 19 - 25 Oct    | Paper 2 cluster C                  | First timed Paper 1 PYQ                 |
| 5    | 26 Oct - 1 Nov | Cluster D + first subject test     | Baseline mock - expect to be humbled    |
| 6    | 2 - 8 Nov      | High-yield depth 1                 | Mock 2 + full review                    |
| 7    | 9 - 15 Nov     | High-yield depth 2                 | Mock 3 - zero unattempted rule enforced |
| 8    | 16 - 22 Nov    | Weak-unit repair                   | Mock 4 + error-log clearing             |
| 9    | 23 - 29 Nov    | Full-syllabus pass                 | Mock 5 - target 170+ sustained          |
| 10   | 30 Nov - 6 Dec | Revision cycle 1                   | Mock 6; admit card out - verify details |
| 11   | 7 - 13 Dec     | Revision cycle 2 + logistics       | Mock 7 (light); centre route planned    |
| 12   | 14 - 19 Dec    | EXAM WEEK                          | Sleep, pacing discipline, mark all 150  |

## The eight most expensive mistakes in NET preparation

Collected from result season after result season - each one is avoidable from today:

- **Waiting for the notification to start studying.** The syllabus is public today; the notification changes dates, not topics.

- **Reading Paper 2 without ever being tested on it.** Recognition feels like knowledge and is not; only retrieval under a clock is.
- **Neglecting Paper 1 as easy.** Its 100 marks are the cheapest in the exam and decide close category boundaries.
- **Filing the form on the last day.** Server congestion, failed payments and hasty city choices all live on the last day.
- **Leaving questions unattempted.** In a no-negative-marking exam this is donating marks to the field.
- **Studying everything to the same depth.** Ten years of PYQs tell you where the marks live; ignoring them is choosing difficulty.
- **No error log.** Repeating a mistake costs a question every cycle; logging it costs one minute.
- **Treating one bad mock as a verdict.** Mocks are instruments, not judgements - the trend across six of them is the signal.



**PART 11****Trackers and templates you will actually use**

A plan without a tracking system is a wish. These three templates are the entire paperwork of an 82-day campaign - copy them into a notebook or a spreadsheet tonight, and fill them honestly every Sunday.

**The weekly tracker (fill every Sunday)**

| Week of                   | Paper 2 units covered | Paper 1 units touched | PYQs solved | Hours logged | One honest sentence |
|---------------------------|-----------------------|-----------------------|-------------|--------------|---------------------|
| 23-29 Sep                 |                       |                       |             |              |                     |
| 30 Sep-6 Oct              |                       |                       |             |              |                     |
| 7-13 Oct                  |                       |                       |             |              |                     |
| 14-20 Oct                 |                       |                       |             |              |                     |
| 21-27 Oct                 |                       |                       |             |              |                     |
| 28 Oct-3 Nov              |                       |                       |             |              |                     |
| ... continue to exam week |                       |                       |             |              |                     |

The one-sentence column is the one that matters. 'Watched three lecture videos' is not a sentence about learning; 'can now solve series questions at 90% accuracy' is. Write sentences a coach would believe.

**The error log (fill after every practice set)**

| Date | Q. no. | Unit / topic | My answer | Correct | Why: didn't know / misread / time |
|------|--------|--------------|-----------|---------|-----------------------------------|
|      |        |              |           |         |                                   |
|      |        |              |           |         |                                   |
|      |        |              |           |         |                                   |

The 'why' column converts a wrong answer into a fix. 'Didn't know' sends you to the textbook; 'misread' sends you to slower question-reading; 'time' sends you to pacing drills. Three different problems, three different medicines - and most candidates take the same medicine (study more) for all three diseases.

**The mock-score log (fill after every full paper)**

| Date | Paper 1 /100 | Paper 2 /200 | Total /300 | Percent | Pacing note |
|------|--------------|--------------|------------|---------|-------------|
|      |              |              |            |         |             |
|      |              |              |            |         |             |
|      |              |              |            |         |             |

Two rules for this log: record every attempt, even the embarrassing ones, and never compare your week-3 mock to anything except your week-2 mock. The target trajectory for a serious candidate: 140-150 by mid-October, 160-175 by mid-November, and 180+ sustained through December. If two consecutive mocks are flat, the answer is almost always in the error log - go back and re-solve every logged mistake before starting anything new.

### **The Sunday review ritual (20 minutes)**

Every Sunday evening, with the week closed, run this in order: fill the weekly tracker (5 minutes), re-solve the five worst error-log entries of the week without looking anything up (10 minutes), and write next-week targets into the honest-sentence column (5 minutes). Twenty minutes a week is the entire administrative overhead of this system - and it is the difference between 82 days of studying and 82 days of improving.

### **The burnout protocol (use it before you need it)**

An 82-day campaign is won by the person still standing in week ten. Three rules that hold across every serious preparation: one full rest evening a week is scheduled rest, not stolen rest - take it guilt-free; sleep is a study technique, because retrieval and pacing collapse without it; and any day that goes wrong is followed by a minimum viable day - thirty minutes of PYQs - never by a total abandonment that turns one bad day into a lost week. Consistency compounds; intensity does not.

**PART 12**

## Two special cases: working professionals and repeat takers

### If you are working full-time

The 82-day plan assumes 3-4 hours on weekdays. If you have a job, you will get 1.5-2 on weekdays and more on weekends - which is enough, on one condition: the weekday hours are for drilling and revision, never for new topics. Learning new material tired, at 10 pm, is where working professionals burn out. The restructure:

- **Mornings, 45 minutes:** one Paper 2 high-yield topic, fresh. New material needs your best brain; give it the morning even if that means sleeping earlier.
- **Evenings, 45-60 minutes:** PYQs and the error log. Practice tolerates tiredness far better than learning does.
- **Weekends, 5-6 hours total:** one full timed paper plus review, plus the week's missed Paper 1 unit.
- **Commute and lunch:** the definition sheets from Part 7's Group A - they are built exactly for this slot.

Move the mock target from 180 to 165-170 and let the taper phase matter more. A working professional who has done six honest full-length mocks beats a full-time aspirant who has read everything and tested nothing - the exam measures retrieval, not accumulation.

### If this is your second (or fifth) attempt

Repeat takers fail for specific, findable reasons - and the most common one is re-studying what already worked. Before starting this plan, spend one forensic hour with your last scorecard and sort your losses into the same three buckets:

- **Knowledge gaps concentrated in a few Paper 2 units** - fix with depth in Phase 1, not with a new textbook; the syllabus has not changed.
- **Paper 1 underperformance** - shockingly common among subject-strong candidates who decided they 'didn't need' Paper 1 practice. Ten PYQ papers later it is 20 free marks; the unit structure repeats every cycle.
- **Pacing - unattempted questions in a no-negative-marking exam** - the cheapest fix in this entire book: finish and mark everything, every time.

One psychological note: the syllabus's stability is now your ally - you are not starting from zero, you are starting from data. Candidates who treat a repeat attempt as a debugging exercise rather than a replay consistently outperform first-timers with equal hours. Use Part 11's templates from day one so this attempt leaves better data than the last one did.

**PART 13****What June 2026's numbers tell you about competition**

NTA's press releases for the June 2026 cycle give the most recent, honest picture of your odds. Learn these numbers not to be discouraged, but to know exactly what game you are playing.

| June 2026 cycle (NTA figures)                         | Number                                   |
|-------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------|
| Registered (84 subjects)                              | 7,73,806                                 |
| Appeared (84 subjects)                                | 6,07,151                                 |
| Qualified - JRF and Assistant Professor (Category 1)  | 4,241                                    |
| Qualified - Assistant Professor and PhD (Category 2)  | 45,904                                   |
| Qualified - PhD only (Category 3)                     | 97,434                                   |
| Total qualified                                       | 1,47,579                                 |
| Re-exam (English, Commerce, Sociology, 9-10 Sep 2026) | 1,20,355 appeared of 1,96,491 registered |
| Re-exam Category 1 / 2 / 3 qualifiers                 | 824 / 11,610 / 23,154                    |

Read the table this way. About one in four candidates who appeared walked away with something - 1.47 lakh qualifiers from 6.07 lakh appearances. But the pyramid is steep: roughly 1% landed the funded fellowship (Category 1), about 8% became Assistant-Professor eligible (Categories 1 and 2), and the largest single group - about two-thirds of all qualifiers - cleared only the PhD-admission bar.

Two more patterns worth knowing. First, more women than men registered - 4.30 lakh female against 3.43 lakh male candidates, about 55.6% versus 44.4%. Second, roughly a fifth of registered candidates did not appear. Simply sitting the exam with real preparation already places you ahead of a fifth of the field; a disciplined 82 days places you ahead of far more.

The categories are a feature, not a consolation prize. A Category-3 result is a nationally valid PhD entrance score for one year, accepted instead of individual university entrance tests - that is a genuine option created for you, not a booby prize. And every attempt you make at NET builds toward the next cycle: the syllabus is stable, and your June 2027 self will start from here.

## PART 14

# After you qualify: certificates, JRF money, PhD admission

Qualifying is a milestone, not a finish line. Here is what actually happens next, and the deadlines hiding inside each step.

## Your scorecard and certificate

Results are declared on the NTA website; NTA does not individually inform candidates. The scorecard is downloadable from the UGC NET portal - but notice from June 2026: candidates whose papers were being re-conducted saw an 'Invalid Application Number/Password' message until the re-exam results arrived. If you see odd portal behaviour, check the public notices before you panic. Eligibility, self-declarations and documents of qualified candidates are verified by the concerned authorities per the bulletin's norms.

## If you qualify for JRF (Category 1)

- The JRF award letter is your key document; the award is valid for **three years** from its date of issue.
- The fellowship pays **Rs. 37,000 per month** (upgrading to **Rs. 42,000** as SRF after two years and successful assessment), plus HRA where hostel accommodation is not provided, as per Central Government norms for your city.
- You still need to find and join a university, IIT or recognised institution to register your PhD - the fellowship funds you; the seat still has to admit you. JRF-qualified candidates are admitted to PhD programmes through an interview under UGC's PhD regulations.

## If you qualify under Category 2 or 3

Your NET score substitutes for individual university PhD entrance tests for one year from the result date, with admission decided on a combined merit of 70% NET score and 30% interview. Practically: identify the universities running PhD admissions in your subject during your validity year, and apply to several - each runs its own interview and its own merit list.

## If you qualify for Assistant Professor (Categories 1-2)

NET is the eligibility certificate, not the job. Universities, colleges and state higher-education departments advertise Assistant Professor recruitments through the year; watch the employment sections of university websites and your state's higher education council. The e-certificate itself is downloaded from the UGC NET portal and stays valid for applying - recruitment rules of the concerned university or state apply to each post.

## The January plan: between exam and result

Results for a mid-December exam should follow around February 2027 on recent timelines (the June 2026 result arrived about two months after the exam). Do not spend those weeks refreshing the portal - spend them on three jobs:

- **Challenge season.** Question papers, provisional answer keys and your recorded responses are published together (in June 2026 they opened for a three-day window). Diary a check every few

days from mid-January; a successfully challenged question is free marks, and it is how candidates flagged the June 2026 paper errors.

- **Documents.** Category, EWS, PwD and result-awaited certificates are verified against the bulletin's norms; make sure every certificate is current and every spelling matches your form.
- **The next lever.** If a state or university Assistant Professor recruitment opens in your subject meanwhile, NET-in-progress is still worth applying where rules allow later joining. If PhD is your path, list the universities whose admission season starts around your expected result date.

## And if you fall short

A score below every cut-off is data, not destiny. The PhD-only category still validates for one year where it applies; the June 2027 cycle is five months after this one; and your error logs, mock scores and definition sheets carry over untouched - the syllabus will not have moved an inch. The candidates who eventually clear NET are rarely the ones who never failed a cycle; they are the ones whose failed cycles left a paper trail good enough to fix.

## Fellowships beyond the JRF list

The information bulletin also routes three Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment fellowships through NET scores: the National Fellowship for Scheduled Caste students (NFSC), the National Fellowship for Other Backward Classes (NFOBC), and the National Fellowship for Persons with Disabilities (NFPwD). If you belong to one of these categories and missed the JRF cut-off narrowly, these fellowships are a parallel funded route into research - check the bulletin and the Ministry notices for the selection process in your cycle.

**PART 15**

## Exam-day protocol

The December 2026 exam is computer-based. Everything below is standard NTA CBT discipline; details for your shift arrive with the admit card.

- **Admit card and photo ID:** a printed admit card plus an original government photo ID (Aadhaar, PAN, passport, voter ID). The name on both must match.
- **Timing:** reach the centre well before reporting time - the gate closes on schedule, and 'well before' is an hour in an unfamiliar city.
- **What leaves your bag:** phones, smartwatches, calculators and study material stay outside the test hall - NTA treats violations as impersonation-level offences. Plan for no pockets of knowledge except the one in your head.
- **Inside the test:** 150 questions, 180 minutes, no negative marking. Budget roughly 60 minutes for Paper 1, 115 for Paper 2, and 5 final minutes to mark every unanswered question.
- **After the test:** your recorded responses and the answer keys are published later for challenge - diarise a check two and four weeks after your exam date. This is also your best free mock-review material.

### Inside the test interface

The CBT screen shows one question at a time with four options, a question palette mapping answered, unanswered and marked-for-review questions by colour, and a running clock. Three habits to rehearse in mocks: use mark-for-review as your parking lot (the palette makes returning effortless), never solve the palette colours into a score prediction mid-exam, and treat the final minutes of the clock as your cue for the marking sweep. The interface is the same one NTA mock tests run - which is why Part 10 insists on a few computer-based practice sessions rather than only paper mocks.

**The 5-minute rule:** with zero negative marking, the last five minutes of the session are free marks. Whatever remains unanswered gets your single best guess. Statistically, random marking across the whole paper converts to about one-third of those questions correct - marks you abandon entirely by leaving blanks.

**PART 16**

## Scams, fake sites and how to stay safe

Every big exam attracts an economy of fake services, and the December 2026 cycle will be no different - especially in the gap between the calendar announcement and the actual notification, when fake 'expected dates' and paid 'early access' forms circulate. Here is the protection checklist.

- **One site, zero exceptions:** [ugcnet.nta.nic.in](http://ugcnet.nta.nic.in). The registration link, admit card, answer keys and results all live there. NTA also posts notices on [nta.ac.in](http://nta.ac.in). Anything else - including apps and 'aggregator' forms - is a third party.
- **The fee is Rs. 1,150 or less.** Nobody legitimate will charge you more. 'Form-filling services' that charge thousands are charging for a form you can file yourself in thirty minutes with this book's Part 5.
- **There is no paid seat, no management quota, no 'NTA insider' leak.** Anyone selling question papers or guaranteed results is selling paper or prison risk.
- **Official communication is only through your registered email and mobile.** Messages arriving on WhatsApp groups or personal social accounts claiming to be NTA are not NTA.
- **Answer-key challenges are free and official.** When the challenge window opens, you raise challenges yourself on the portal - the June 2026 re-exam of three papers began exactly there, with candidates flagging errors through the official process.

A calm rule for the whole cycle: money flows in exactly one direction, to NTA's payment gateway, exactly once, at the published fee. Any other flow of money or documents is a red flag by definition.



**PART 17****Your resource shelf**

Everything on this shelf is official and free. No paid resource is required to clear NET; discipline is the scarce input, not material.

| Resource                             | Where                                                    | Why you need it                                         |
|--------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|
| UGC NET portal                       | <a href="http://ugcnet.nta.nic.in">ugcnet.nta.nic.in</a> | Registration, notices, admit card, answer keys, results |
| NTA notices                          | <a href="http://nta.ac.in">nta.ac.in</a>                 | Press releases, calendars, re-exam announcements        |
| Paper 1 and Paper 2 syllabi          | <a href="http://ugcnetonline.in">ugcnetonline.in</a>     | The official topic list for every subject               |
| Information bulletin (when released) | UGC NET portal                                           | The legal source for fees, dates, eligibility           |
| Previous years' question papers      | UGC NET portal archive                                   | Your truest guide to weight and difficulty              |
| NTA mock tests                       | Link on the UGC NET portal                               | Computer-based practice in the real interface           |

A note on coaching material: use it for structure if you want it, but grade everything against the official syllabus and PYQs. If a chapter never appears in ten years of papers, it is decoration. The exam has always rewarded the person who finished the syllabus three times over the person who owned the most expensive bundle.

**PART 18****NET jargon, translated**

Every term below appears in official notices and in this book. Read this page once; the vocabulary stops being scary once it stops being unfamiliar.

| Term                              | Plain meaning                                                                                                |
|-----------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| CBT                               | Computer-Based Test - you answer on a computer at a centre, not on paper                                     |
| JRF                               | Junior Research Fellowship - the funded-research result (Rs. 37,000/month), age-limited, 3-year validity     |
| SRF                               | Senior Research Fellowship - JRF upgraded to Rs. 42,000/month after two years and successful assessment      |
| Assistant Professor (eligibility) | Qualification to apply for university/college teaching posts; the job itself is separate recruitment         |
| Category 1 / 2 / 3                | The three result bands: JRF+teaching+PhD / teaching+PhD / PhD only                                           |
| Aggregate                         | Paper 1 + Paper 2 combined (out of 300); every cut-off applies to this, never to one paper alone             |
| Percentile                        | The percentage of candidates you scored above; used in the result and for PhD admission                      |
| Equi-percentile normalisation     | Statistical adjustment when a subject runs in multiple shifts so scores are comparable                       |
| Buffer dates                      | Reserve exam days (20-21 Dec 2026) kept for re-runs if a scheduled day is disrupted                          |
| City intimation                   | Advance notice of your exam city, before the admit card names the exact centre                               |
| Correction window                 | A few days after registration closes when form errors can be fixed                                           |
| Recorded responses                | Your exact clicks in the exam, published with the answer key for challenges                                  |
| Answer-key challenge              | The official, free process to dispute a question - how June 2026's faulty papers were flagged                |
| OBC-NCL                           | Other Backward Classes, Non-Creamy Layer, per the Central list on nbc.nic.in - the only OBC that counts here |
| EWS                               | Economically Weaker Section - requires a valid certificate for the fee and cut-off benefits                  |
| PwD / PwBD                        | Persons with (Benchmark) Disability - extra relaxations and scribe provisions                                |
| Scribe portal                     | Where PwD/PwBD candidates register scribe details in advance (opened for June 2026)                          |
| Meri Pehchan                      | Government single sign-on service usable for NTA registration                                                |
| e-Certificate                     | The downloadable NET qualification certificate; your proof for job applications                              |
| Information bulletin              | The official PDF for the cycle - the legal source for every date, fee and rule                               |

**PART 19**

## Frequently asked questions

**Is the December 2026 registration open?**

Not as of 23 September 2026. The exam dates (14-19 December, buffers 20-21 December) are confirmed via NTA's calendar released 16 September 2026; the application window is expected in October based on recent cycles. Check the official portal twice a week.

**Can final-year Master's students apply?**

Yes - you are admitted provisionally and must secure the required percentage within two years of the NET result (one year for the PhD-only category).

**Is there negative marking?**

No. +2 per correct answer, 0 for wrong or unattempted. Attempt all 150 questions.

**What is the age limit?**

Only JRF has one: not more than 30 on 1 December 2026, with relaxations up to five years for women, OBC-NCL, SC, ST, PwD/PwBD and third-gender candidates, three for LLM holders, and up to five for research experience or armed-forces service - total relaxation capped at five years. Assistant Professor and PhD admission have no upper age limit.

**How many attempts do I get?**

There is no limit on attempts for Assistant Professor or PhD eligibility. For JRF, the age limit is the binding constraint, not an attempt count.

**What score do I need?**

The floor is 40% aggregate (General) or 35% (reserved categories). Real cut-offs are set by the top-6% slot rule and vary by subject and category; aim at 60% (180/300) in mocks.

**Which is better, JRF or Assistant Professor eligibility?**

They are different prizes. JRF funds full-time research (Rs. 37,000 per month) with an age bar. Assistant Professor eligibility has no age bar and applies to teaching recruitment. If you are under 30, select both options - the exam sorts you into categories automatically.

**Can I appear in two subjects?**

One application, one subject per cycle. If you submit multiple forms, only the first is considered.

**How long is my result valid?**

JRF: three years from the award letter. For PhD admission (Categories 2-3): one year from the result date. Assistant Professor eligibility: for life, subject to recruitment rules at the time of each application.

**I missed this cycle's registration. What now?**

The next cycle follows in mid-2027. Your preparation is never wasted - the syllabus is stable across cycles, and Part 10's plan works for any 80-to-180-day runway.

**How many mocks are enough?**

Six to ten full-length, timed papers between mid-October and exam week - the number at which the pacing table in Part 6 stops requiring thought. Beyond that, review quality beats additional attempts.

**Coaching or self-study?**

NET rewards the person who finished the syllabus three times over the person who owns the most expensive bundle. Coaching can supply structure; PYQs, the official syllabus, and the templates in Part 11 supply everything else.

**Is the exam available in Hindi?**

NET is conducted bilingually (English and Hindi) for the standard papers; check the bulletin for your subject's language options when it is released.

**I have a gap year / career break. Does it hurt?**

For NET itself, no - there is no interview, no CV, no gap-year question. The exam sees only your 150 answers.

**Are there accommodations for PwD candidates?**

Yes - a scribe facility (June 2026 ran a dedicated advance portal for registering scribe details), compensatory time and relaxed eligibility percentages; the bulletin PwD section is the controlling text.

**Can I change my subject after submitting the form?**

Only within the correction window if one opens, and only where the bulletin permits; programme, category and similar locked fields generally cannot change after submission. Choose carefully the first time.

**How do I download the e-certificate after qualifying?**

From the UGC NET portal after results and verification - watch the public notices for the e-certificate window announcement; it does not arrive automatically by post.

**THE ONE-PAGE BRIEF****Read this the night before, and again with your morning tea**

| The facts        |                                                                                |
|------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Papers           | Paper 1: 50 questions, 100 marks. Paper 2: 100 questions, 200 marks            |
| Session          | One 3-hour sitting, no break, computer-based                                   |
| Marking          | +2 per correct answer. No negative marking. Ever.                              |
| Your only job    | 150 attempted questions - including best-guess marks on every parked one       |
| Pacing           | Paper 1 in ~55 minutes; Paper 2 gets the rest; final 5-minute sweep for blanks |
| Carry            | Printed admit card + original photo ID, names matching                         |
| Leave outside    | Phone, smartwatch, calculator, notes - the entire category                     |
| Reach            | A full hour before reporting time                                              |
| During the paper | Flag and move; the palette remembers so you do not have to                     |
| Result timing    | Likely February 2027; challenge window opens with answer keys first            |

You prepared with a plan while others prepared with anxiety. That difference is worth percentile bands. Good luck - go collect your marks.

**PART 20**

## Sources and verification

Every date, rule and number in this playbook was verified against these official sources (as on 23 September 2026). When the December 2026 information bulletin is released, re-check fees and dates against it - it supersedes everything, including this book.

- National Testing Agency, UGC NET official portal - [ugcnet.nta.nic.in](http://ugcnet.nta.nic.in) (public notices, information bulletin, candidate activity timeline)
- NTA advance examination calendar notice, 16 September 2026 - December 2026 UGC NET dates of 14-19 December, buffers 20-21 December
- Information Bulletin of UGC-NET June 2026, NTA - exam pattern, marking scheme, eligibility, age relaxations, fee schedule, application procedure, result-preparation steps (6% rule, 40/35% floor, equi-percentile normalisation)
- UGC-NET June 2026 Frequently Asked Questions, NTA - paper structure, JRF validity, age limits
- UGC public notice, 'National Eligibility Test as an Entrance Test for Admission to Ph.D.' - the three-category result system, 70:30 PhD admission weightage, one-year score validity
- NTA press release, 17 September 2026 - re-conduct of English, Commerce and Sociology papers and their result figures
- NTA result announcements, August 2026 (as reported by NDTV and The Times of India) - June 2026 registration, appearance and qualification figures
- Ministry of Education / UGC fellowship revision notifications, 2023 - JRF Rs. 37,000 and SRF Rs. 42,000 per month with effect from 1 January 2023
- December-session application timelines (2023, 2024, 2025 cycles) as reported by Shiksha and other education news outlets - basis for the 'expected October' registration estimate

**Final word.** Eighty-two days is enough. Not comfortable, not luxurious - enough. The syllabus is finite, the pattern is stable, and the competition is mostly unprepared. File the form early, run the plan, mark every question, and let the percentiles take care of themselves. See you on the other side of 14 December.